Szymborska, 1996: the answer that will not hold



Wisława Szymborska, Kraków, 2009.

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Wisława Szymborska, “The poet and the world”, Nobel Lecture 1996. Polish original; English by Barańczak and Cavanagh. Copyright The Nobel Foundation 1996.

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Stockholm, 7 December 1996. Szymborska is asked to say what a poet does.



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Natchnienie, czymkolwiek ono jest, rodzi się z bezustannego “nie wiem”.

Whatever inspiration is, it’s born from a continuous “I don’t know.”

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Whatever inspiration is, it's born from a continuous "I don't know."

Każdym utworem próbuje na to odpowiedzieć, ale kiedy tylko postawi kropkę, już ogarnia go wahanie … Więc próbuje jeszcze raz i jeszcze raz.

Each poem marks an effort to answer this statement, but as soon as the final period hits the page, the poet begins to hesitate … So the poets keep on trying.

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Popper, 1934: conjecture and refutation

Plate not present

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Karl Popper, about 1980.

LSE Library

Karl Popper, *The Logic of Scientific Discovery*, chapter 10, section 85 (1959), the authorised English of *Logik der Forschung* (1934).

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Vienna, 1934. Popper asks what entitles anyone to believe a general rule drawn from finitely many cases.

His answer is that nothing does, and that this is survivable.

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We do not know: we can only guess.

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Popper's tetradic schema

The way in which knowledge progresses … is by unjustified (and unjustifiable) anticipations, by guesses, by tentative solutions to our problems, by conjectures. These conjectures are controlled by criticism; that is, by attempted refutations …

Schema after Karl Popper, *Objective Knowledge*, chapter 8 (1972). Quotation: *Conjectures and Refutations*, preface (1963). English original.

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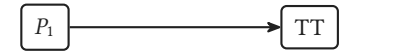


Problem

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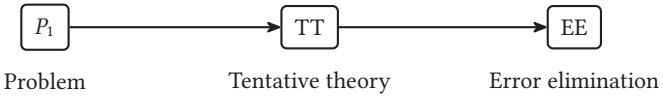
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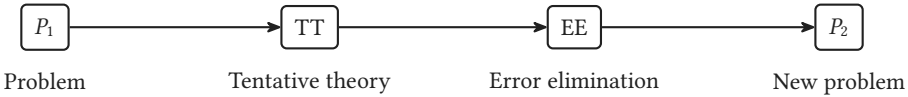
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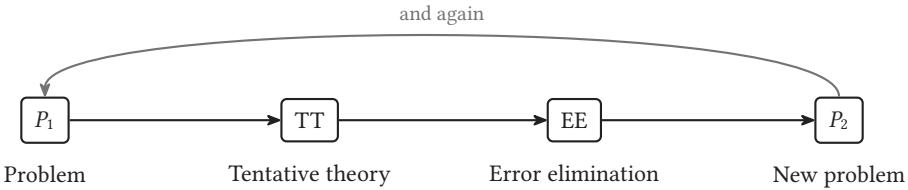
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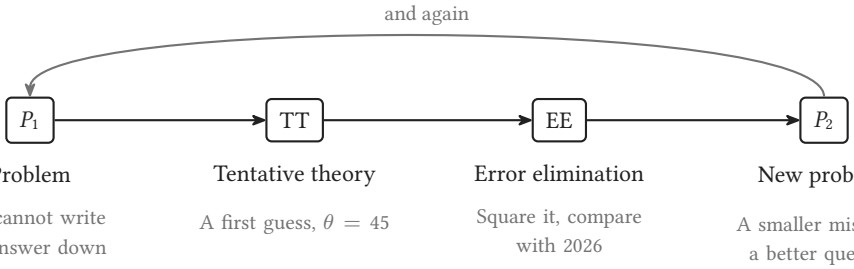
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Turing, 1950: the child machine



Alan Turing, 29 March 1951.

Elliott and Fry

A. M. Turing, “Computing Machinery and Intelligence”, *Mind* LIX(236), 1950, section 7, Learning Machines.

English original. The muted line is this deck’s paraphrase, not a translation.

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We cannot expect to find a good child-machine at the first attempt. One must experiment with teaching one such machine and see how well it learns. One can then try another and see if it is better or worse.

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Now the learning process may be regarded as a search for a form of behaviour which will satisfy the teacher (or some other criterion).

You do not get it right the first time. You try, you measure, you try again.

A. M. Turing, "Computing Machinery and Intelligence", *Mind* LIX(236), 1950, section 7, Learning Machines.

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Whewell, 1858: trying wrong guesses



William Whewell, stipple engraving.

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William Whewell, *Novum Organon Renovatum*, third edition (1858), book II, chapter V, section I, page 79.

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The tendencies of our speculative nature … perpetually show their vigour by overshooting the mark. They obtain something, by aiming at much more.

Most guesses are wrong, and a step that aims too far is how the right one gets found.

William Whewell, *Novum Organon Renovatum*, third edition (1858), book II, chapter V, section I, page 79.

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